

Q Pregnancy seems to have me elated one minute and devastated the next. Is this normal?

During your first trimester, the hormonal changes in your body are rapid and raging. It's a primeval response that ensures you maintain your pregnancy. These surges, primarily in the hormones estrogen and progesterone, upset the chemical balance in your brain, causing neurotransmitters—your brain's chemical messengers—to switch on and off randomly. And that's what gives you the mood swings.

In many cases, your mood will settle down by week 12. However, some women continue to experience severe highs and lows and may be diagnosed with prenatal depression. This is as common as postpartum depression and can be just as serious. In addition to fluctuating hormones, there are other causes of prenatal depression such as anxiety about your pregnancy, feeling sick and tired, feeling low, previous depression, fear of something going wrong and isolation. If your mood swings are very extreme, or you suspect you may be suffering from depression (and almost 10 percent of women are thought to experience this during pregnancy), speak to your doctor, who will be able to get you the treatment you need.

Q What can I do to help myself manage my emotions?

There are many self-help techniques you can employ. Try some of these quick fixes when you feel a negative mood—sadness or irritation—taking hold:

- » Walk around the block or through a park, even if it's just for 10 minutes. Fresh air and a change of scenery are sometimes all you need to clear your head.
- » Have a healthy snack since sugar lows exacerbate negative feelings or irritation so keep your energy levels stable.
- » Write a letter explaining how you are feeling. Even if you never send it, it can help to put things into perspective.
- » Knead some dough, make cookies, or make something that involves using some elbow grease. Physical exertion can help you to work through what's troubling you and may provide an outlet for your pent-up adrenaline.

Q I am so forgetful. Is there really such a thing as “baby brain?”

Anecdotal evidence suggests that forgetfulness and lack of concentration are natural side effects of pregnancy. Scientists are still trying to find out if there is a physiological reason for this, with one recent study proposing that the emotional parts of the brain “plump up” during pregnancy and the more logical, functional parts wind down in order to maximize the mother's instinct for responding empathetically to her baby immediately after birth.

However, there are still questions about why physiological brain changes happen, if they do, with some studies pointing the blame at hormones. Experts tend to agree, though, that you are more tired, stressed, and distracted during pregnancy so the energy you have for clear thinking zooms in on important things (your health and that of your developing baby) rather than where you put the car keys. Just try to get as much rest as possible and be assured that there is no evidence to suggest that “baby brain”—physiological or anecdotal—lasts any longer than pregnancy itself, and the effects will reverse after birth.

Q My mood swings are causing spats with my partner. How can we learn to deal with them better?

First things first—get your partner on board. Learn about the hormonal changes of pregnancy together and try to rationalize your irrationality.

Your partner is less likely to take anything you throw at him personally if he knows what's happening in your body. Learning to support your mood swings, rather than dismissing or escalating them, is a key role for your partner, and should not be underestimated. Remember, too, that while the hormones are affecting your body, anxiety, nervousness, and excitement about impending parenthood are things that you both feel. Indeed, your partner may feel overwhelmed by the thought of an added responsibility.

Try counting to 10 when either of you is irritable and feels like snapping. It won't always work, but if enough seconds can elapse before you speak, your words are more likely to be constructive, conciliatory, or placatory.

Make time for physical contact such as holding hands as you walk down the street. Even giving each other a hug at the end of a tiring day will give you a surge of endorphins and oxytocin—feel-good hormones that help to stabilize your moods.

Find time to escape into your own personal space, if this suits the kind of person you are. Perhaps this happens naturally when you go to work, or maybe it means that one of you curls up with a book while the other takes a bath.

Make time for activities together that aren't related to the baby—give yourselves constant reminders of the good things about your relationship, so that when your mood swings you have a recent memory of why the two of you make a good team.

